

Silvia Téliz

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Summary

I am a PhD candidate (expected July 2027) at the Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania, studying visual political communication and social biases in multimodal AI systems. I combine computer vision, natural language processing, and machine learning to analyze large-scale multimodal data, from TikTok content, to street political advertisements. My dissertation project, Visual Cues as Political Communication: A Computational Look into Mexican Federal Electoral Campaigns, examines how skin tone and other visual cues influence electoral outcomes in Mexico. I have also conducted research on the nature of social biases in large language models and visual language models. My work has been published in the International Journal of Press/Politics and presented at conferences such as IC2S2 and PolNet-PACSS. I have extensive experience in teaching and mentoring students, having served as a teaching fellow for two courses at the Annenberg School for Communication, and as an instructor of record at Universidad Panamericana.

Education

PhD in Communication, Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania	2027
Degree expected in July 2027. Dissertation title: 'Visual Cues as Political Communication: A Computational Look into Mexican Federal Electoral Campaigns'. Committee: Dr. Sandra González-Bailón (chair), Dr. Deen Freelon, Dr. Yphtach Lelkes.	
Master of Arts in Communication, Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania	2024
Bachelor of Arts in Communication, Universidad Panamericana (Mexico City, Mexico)	2018

Technical Skills and Methodologies

Methods: Computational visual analysis, natural language processing, machine learning, social media data collection, survey and experiment design, content analysis

Programming: Python, R, Git, HTML, CSS

Software: Gephi, Adobe Illustrator, GitHub, Stata

AI Tools and Deployment: Hugging Face Transformers, Ollama, OpenRouter, proprietary LLM APIs (Anthropic, OpenAI, Gemini), PyTorch

Languages: Spanish: native speaker, English: advanced (C2), French: intermediate (B2), German: intermediate (B1)

Publications

Skin Tone as a Visual Cue in Political Campaigns: Evidence from Elections in Mexico Silvia Téliz, Sandra González-Bailón International Journal of Press/Politics (in press)	2026
WhichTok? Comparing Three TikTok Data Acquisition Tools Gayoung Jeon, Cameron Moy, Silvia Téliz, Cristina Monzer, Nicolette Alayon, Deen Freelon arxiv.org/abs/2608.09917 (arXiv preprint)	2026
Poder Prieto: Media, Colorism, and Cultural Activism in Mexico Juan Llamas-Rodríguez, Silvia Téliz nyupress.org/9781479835164/planet-digital (Planet Digital, NYU Press)	2026
Agresiones a periodistas y cobertura mediática de la corrupción Georgina Flores-Ivich, Silvia Téliz 10.2307/j.ctv1jhvn9w (Crisis de estatalidad y violaciones a derechos humanos, FLACSO México)	2021

Research Experience

Research Fellow, Politics, Identities, and Communication Lab – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania May 2025 – present

- Secured \$10,000 USD via the Annenberg School for Communication Internal Grant for the project ‘Identifying Biases in VLMs’ Zero-Shot Classifications of Race and Gender’ (2026-2027 academic year), as lead researcher.
- Collaborated on the theoretical conceptualization, formulation of overarching research goals, methodology design, computational analysis of text and image data, writing, reviewing, and editing for projects developed within the lab under Dr. Deen Freelon’s supervision.

Research Fellow, Center for Advanced Research in Global Communication – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania Aug 2022 – Aug 2023

- Collaborated with Dr. Juan Llamas Rodríguez on the development of a mixed-methods study on the representation of gender and skin color stereotypes in Mexican telenovelas and TV series (a report commissioned by the Luminate foundation).

Research Assistant, Facultad Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales (FLACSO) – Mexico City, Mexico 2018 – 2022

- Coordinated a research consulting project to identify the strengths and weaknesses of the evaluation system of information transparency for the National Institute of Access to Information and Personal Data Protection.
- Developed an academic program and created didactic content for the National School for Women of the Institutional Revolutionary Party, empowering female members through education on gender perspective, political representation, and communication strategies.
- Created educational content for the Migrant-e project (led by the Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México), teaching undocumented immigrants in the United States about their rights and safety tools.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Fellow, Introduction to Communication Behavior – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania Jan 2026 – May 2026

- Taught lecture ‘Media Effects on Community and Everyday Culture’.
- Taught recitation section, providing students with additional support and guidance on course materials.
- Tutored students on how to improve their studying strategies and reading comprehension skills for weekly exams. Provided guidance on the development of a research plan for their final projects.

Teaching Fellow, Children and Media – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania Aug 2024 – Dec 2024

- Taught lecture ‘Racial Representations in Children’s Media’.
- Clarified students’ doubts and provided additional support on course materials during dedicated office hours.

Instructor of Record, Quantitative Methods for Communication Research – Universidad Panamericana, Mexico City Jan 2020 – Dec 2022

- Taught introductory course on quantitative research methods for students in the Communication major.
- Introduced R into the curriculum as the main tool for learning Quantitative Methods.
- Guided students through in-class exercises, which included statistical analysis, data visualization, and interpretation of results using R.
- Designed original educational materials, including slides, assignments, tests, and lab activities.

Presentations

Understanding Bias in AI Systems September 2026
Silvia Téliz

Guest lecture. COM 107 AI and Creativity, Stony Brook University - Stony Brook, NY, USA

Mechanisms of Social Bias in Large Language Models: Disentangling Linguistic Framing from Group Specification July 2026

Vishwanath Emani Venkata, Silvia Téliz

Conference presentation. IC2S2 conference - Burlington, VT, USA

Picturing Immigration: A Multimodal Computational Analysis of the 2024 U.S. Presidential Campaign	August 2025
Silvia Téliz, Gayoung Jeon	
<i>Poster presentation.</i> PolNet-PACSS conference - Boston, MA, USA	
A Picture is Worth a Thousand Fictions: Visual Political Communication in the Age of Generative AI	April 2025
Silvia Téliz	
<i>Invited talk.</i> CIND Workshop 2025 - Philadelphia, PA, USA	
Hues of Victory: Using Computer Vision to Examine Skin Color's Influence on Electoral Success	June 2024
Silvia Téliz	
<i>Conference presentation.</i> ICA Preconference: "A Computational Turn in Journalism: Opportunities and Challenges in a Cross-Disciplinary Field" - Singapore	
Status, Color and Race: Dissecting the content of Latin American class stereotypes	May 2023
Valentina Proust Iligaray, Silvia Téliz	
<i>Conference presentation.</i> ICA Preconference: "Media and Communication in Global Latinidades" - Online	

Honors and Awards

Annenberg School for Communication Internal Grant	2026
\$10,000 USD, principal investigator, for the project 'Identifying Biases in VLMs' Zero-Shot Classifications of Race and Gender' (2026-2027 academic year).	
Graduate Scholarship in Sciences and Humanities	2025
Awarded by the Ministry of Science, Humanities, Technology and Innovation of Mexico (SECIHTI)	
Fulbright García-Robles Scholarship	2022
Awarded by the US-Mexico Foundation (COMEXUS)	

Certificates

Summer Institute in Computational Social Science	2026
Awarded by the University of Pennsylvania	
Certificate in College and University Teaching	2025
Awarded by the University of Pennsylvania	

Scholarly Memberships and Service

Center for Information Networks and Democracy – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania	2023 – present
Doctoral fellow and meeting administrator	
Center for Advanced Research in Global Communication – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania	2022 – 2025
Doctoral fellow	
Graduate Student Council – Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania	2023 – 2024
Member and information manager	